

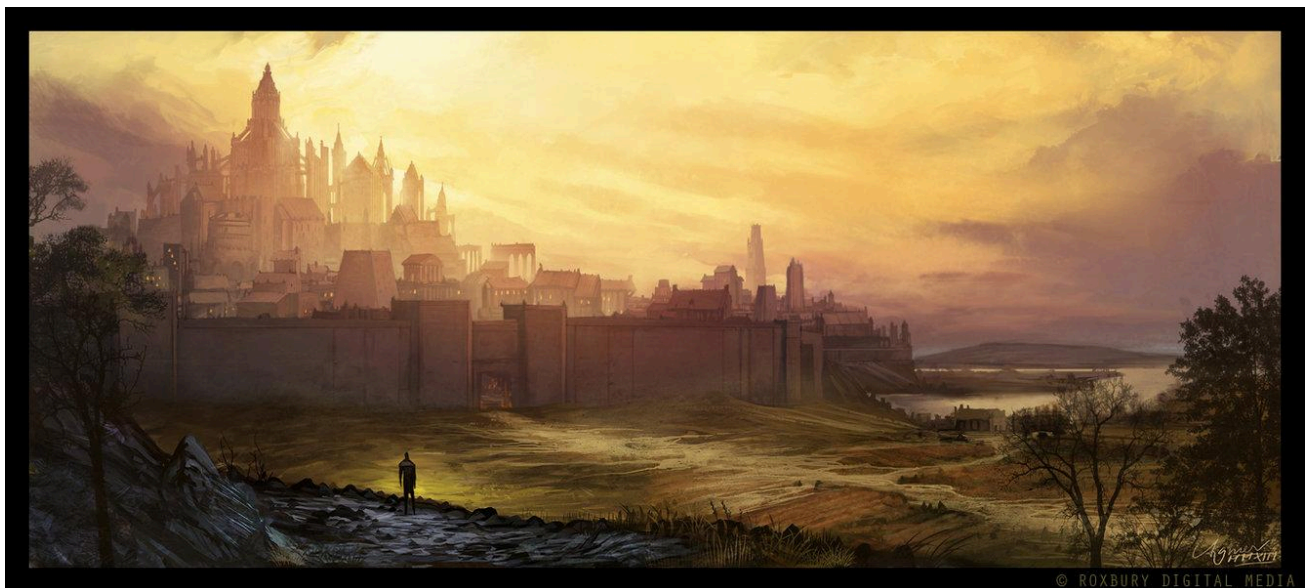
A VISITOR'S GUIDE TO ELTUREL

The Jewel of the Western Heartlands

"Where the Companion watches and the righteous walk without fear."

— Common saying among Elturel's citizens

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Welcome to Elturel

Greetings, traveler. Whether you arrive by road along the Chionthar, by boat from Berdusk, or by the grace of good fortune, you have reached one of the finest cities in all the Western Heartlands. Elturel welcomes you.

Elturel is a city of faith, commerce, and light. It stands on a bluff above the River Chionthar, its streets well-kept and its people proud. For generations it has served as a beacon of order in a region that has known more than its share of darkness. Adventurers, merchants, pilgrims, and soldiers have all found a home here, and the city has grown stronger for it.

This guide has been prepared by the Office of the High Rider to help visitors make the most of their time within our walls. Within these pages you will find information on the city's history, its layout, its laws, its people, and the many services available to those who pass through.

A Quick Note on the Companion

The great orb of radiant light that hangs above Elturel is called the Companion. It arrived roughly fifty years ago under mysterious circumstances and has burned in the sky above the city ever since, providing eternal daylight within the city walls and warding away undead. Do not be alarmed. It is not on fire. Locals are accustomed to questions about it and are generally happy to discuss it over a meal or a drink.

A Brief History

Origins and Early Days

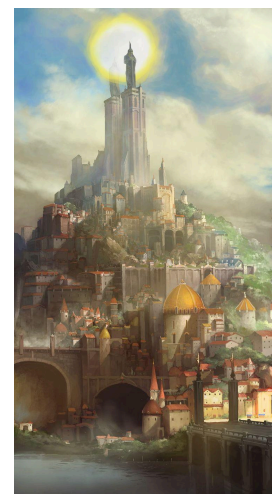
Elturel began as a river crossing and small fortress settlement, one of many that dotted the banks of the Chionthar as civilization pushed westward through the Heartlands. For much of its early history it was a modest but strategically valuable town, frequently contested by bandits, warlords, and worse.

The city grew slowly but steadily over the centuries, bolstered by trade along the river and the protection of successive lords who understood that a strong Elturel was good for business in the entire region. By the time of the Companion's arrival, it had already established itself as a regional hub of commerce and a waypoint for travelers moving between Baldur's Gate to the west and the interior cities to the east.

The Arrival of the Companion

Approximately fifty years ago, Elturel faced one of the darkest periods in its history. Vampires, liches, and undead of every description had overrun the surrounding countryside, and the city itself was besieged. In desperation, the ruling council made a bargain — the exact nature of which remains a matter of scholarly debate — and the Companion appeared.

The great orb of radiant light rose over the city and has never set. Undead that approach within its light are destroyed. The city's defenders rallied. The darkness was driven back. In the decades since, Elturel has flourished as never before, its reputation as a city of order and light drawing the faithful, the ambitious, and the simply weary from across the Heartlands.



Few in the city ask hard questions about the Companion's origin. It protects them. It is enough.

Elturel Today

The city is governed by the High Rider, a title held currently by Thavius Kreeg, a man of deep faith and steady governance who has held the position for over a decade. Beneath him serves a council of advisors drawn from the city's merchant guilds, temples, and military orders. The Hellriders — Elturel's legendary cavalry — remain one of the most respected martial forces in the region, known for riding out against threats that other cities would simply close their gates against.

Elturel is not a perfect city. Like all places of its size, it has its shadows — neighborhoods where the watch patrols less frequently, docks where questions go unasked, and corners of the market where the goods may not have come by honest means. But on the whole it is a city where an honest traveler can walk the streets without fear, sleep without one eye open, and leave with their purse intact.

The City and Its Districts

Elturel sits on a rocky bluff above the northern bank of the River Chionthar, giving it commanding views of the surrounding countryside and the river trade below. The city is divided into several distinct districts, each with its own character and purpose.

The High District

The uppermost part of the bluff, home to the palace of the High Rider, the primary temples, and the residences of the city's most prominent citizens. The streets here are wide, well-paved, and patrolled regularly. Visitors are welcome but observed.

The Dock District

Running along the riverbank below the bluff, the Dock District is the city's commercial heart. Warehouses, counting houses, ferry docks, and the offices of every merchant guild of note can be found here. It is loud, busy, and smells of the river. It is also where most visitors arrive and where most business gets done.

The Market Quarter

The broad central district where the city's daily markets are held. Permanent shops line the main avenues while temporary stalls fill the squares on market days. Nearly anything can be purchased here if you know where to look and have the coin to spend.

The Temple District

Clustered around the great plaza of the Companion's light, the Temple District houses shrines and full temples to more than a dozen faiths. The temples of Torm, Helm, and Lathander are the largest and most prominent, but travelers of nearly any faith will find a place of worship here.

The Reach

The outermost residential district, where the majority of Elturel's working population lives. Craftsmen, laborers, soldiers, and small merchants make their homes here. The streets are narrower, the buildings older, and the watch somewhat less visible, but the neighborhood is largely safe and its residents fiercely proud of it.

The River Gate

The fortified entrance to the city from the river road, where goods and travelers are inspected before being permitted to enter. The gate itself is an impressive piece of engineering and the guards stationed there are professional and thorough.

Laws and Order

What You Need to Know

Elturel maintains strict but fair laws, enforced by the City Watch and ultimately by the Hellriders. Visitors are expected to know and follow the law regardless of where they have come from. Ignorance is not considered a defense, though the Watch is generally willing to explain the rules to a first-time offender before making an arrest.

The Iron Rules of Elturel

The following are the laws most commonly encountered by visitors and most strictly enforced: No unsheathed weapons in temples, the High District, or the market squares without written permission from the Watch. Magical effects that affect the mind, memory, or will of another person without their consent are a serious crime. Necromantic magic of any kind within the city walls is strictly forbidden. All merchants operating within the city must be licensed. Unlicensed selling is treated as theft. Crimes committed against pilgrims, clergy, or the elderly carry double the standard penalty.

The City Watch

The Watch operates out of four garrison houses spread across the city's districts. They are generally competent and honest, though their attention and response time vary considerably between the High District and the Reach. Visitors who wish to report a crime or seek assistance should look for the blue lantern hung above each garrison entrance.

Visitors who carry weapons — and the city understands that adventurers and travelers often do — are expected to keep blades sheathed in populated areas. A peace-bonded weapon is a courteous weapon. The Watch will not confiscate arms from legitimate travelers, but they will remember the ones who cause trouble.

The Hellriders

Elturel's legendary cavalry are not simply city guards on horseback. They are a martial order with a long history of riding against threats that no city watch could handle — undead hordes, bandit armies, creatures from the wilds. When the Hellriders ride out, it means the situation is serious and the city means it.

Visitors should treat the Hellriders with respect and give way to them on the road. An obstruction to a Hellrider on active duty is treated as interference with city law enforcement, which carries significant penalties.

Commerce and Trade

The Market Quarter

The Market Quarter operates six days out of seven, with Highsunday observed as a day of rest in accordance with the customs of the Companion's faith. On market days the central squares are filled with traders from across the Heartlands and beyond — Berdusk cloth, Baldur's Gate spices, goods from the interior, and the products of Elturel's own considerable craftsmen.

Prices in Elturel are generally fair and regulated by the merchant guilds, which means visitors are less likely to be gouged here than in some cities of comparable size. Hagglng is acceptable in the open market but considered somewhat rude in the permanent shops, where prices are posted and expected to be paid.

Currency and Exchange

Accepted Currencies	Guild Marks
Standard gold, silver, and copper coins from any major mint are accepted throughout the city. Foreign coins are exchanged at the Merchant's Counting House near the River Gate.	Established merchants may carry Guild Marks, which function as letters of credit. Visitors unfamiliar with the system should inquire at the Counting House.

Notable Establishments

The following establishments have been recommended to the Office of the High Rider by residents and regular visitors alike. The Office does not formally endorse any private business but provides this list as a convenience to travelers.

- The Pair of Black Antlers — The finest inn in the Dock District and the preferred stopping point for wealthy merchants and their agents. Expensive but worth it for the beds alone.
 - The Tipped Flagon — A lively tavern in the Market Quarter, popular with adventurers, soldiers, and anyone who wants a loud evening and a strong drink. Ontharr Frume has been known to hold court here.
 - The Smiling Ox — A reliable, affordable inn near the River Gate. The food is plain but generous and the owner, a retired guardsman named Hessa, runs a tight ship.
 - Caldra's Remedies — An apothecary in the Temple District with an unusually well-stocked selection of medicinal and magical supplies. The proprietor is prickly but honest.
 - The Counting House of the Chionthar — The primary money-changing and banking institution for visiting merchants. Fees are reasonable and the security is exceptional.
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Faith and the Temples

Elturel is a profoundly faithful city. The presence of the Companion has reinforced a culture of devotion, and temples here are among the best-maintained and most active in the region. Visitors of faith will find their traditions respected and, in most cases, a house of worship that serves them.

The Major Temples

- Temple of Torm — The largest and most politically influential temple in the city, located in the High District near the palace. The Order of the Gauntlet maintains a strong presence here. The temple is open to all for prayer but holds its high rites for initiates.
- Temple of Helm — An austere and imposing structure in the Temple District. The faithful of Helm are dedicated to vigilance and protection. The temple operates a free healing service for the city's poor on the first day of each tenday.
- Temple of Lathander — The most welcoming of the major temples, the Lathander shrine opens its doors at dawn every day for public worship and operates a small but excellent library open to all.
- Shrine of Selune — A modest but beloved shrine in the Reach, tended by a small community of the Moonmaiden's faithful. Popular with travelers, sailors, and those who work by night.

A Note for Non-Human Visitors

Elturel welcomes visitors of all races and backgrounds. The city's laws apply equally to all, and the Watch is expected to enforce them without bias. Travelers who experience discrimination from city officials should report it to the Watch garrison in their district. Private citizens and establishments may set their own policies regarding entry, but such establishments are in the minority in Elturel and those that practice open discrimination tend not to thrive long in a city that values its reputation for fairness.

Practical Information for Visitors

Getting Around

Elturel is a walkable city for those who do not mind hills. The bluff that the city sits on means that moving from the Dock District to the High District involves a significant climb, and most visitors find that the upper and lower city feel almost like two separate places connected by steep switchback roads and the occasional set of public stairs.

Horses and wagons are permitted throughout the city but movement is slow on market days. Several stables operate near the River Gate and the Market Quarter for those who wish to board their animals while they conduct business on foot. Prices are posted at each stable entrance.

Getting In and Out

By Road

The city's main gates are open from sunrise to two hours past sunset. Late arrivals may request entry through the River Gate guardhouse for a small fee. The roads from Berdusk to the east and the Trade Way to the west are well-maintained and regularly patrolled.

By River

Ferry and barge traffic on the Chionthar is heavy during trading season. The Dock District handles most river traffic. Travelers arriving by private boat should report to the Harbor Warden's office before unloading cargo.

Healing and Medicine

Serious injuries can be treated at the Temple of Helm, which offers free healing services for the poor and fee-based services for those who can afford them. The Temple of Lathander also maintains a small hospice. Private healers and apothecaries operate throughout the Market Quarter and the Reach.

Visitors are advised not to rely on tavern remedies for serious wounds. Elturel has excellent healers and you are unlikely to regret spending the coin.

Safety

Elturel is among the safer cities of its size in the Heartlands. The Companion's light deters undead, and the Watch maintains a visible presence in most districts. Visitors should nonetheless observe standard precautions: keep valuables secured, be cautious in unfamiliar neighborhoods after dark, and do not flash coin in the Dock District.

The city has no formal adventurers' quarter, but adventuring parties are common and generally well-regarded so long as they cause no damage to property and settle their bar tabs. Those seeking work should inquire at the notice boards maintained by the Watch outside each garrison house, or visit the merchants' guilds in the Dock District.

A Final Word

Elturel endures because its people choose to build something worth protecting. Whatever brought you to our city — trade, faith, adventure, or simple passage — we hope you find what you are looking for within our walls.

Travel safely. Keep your sword sheathed until you need it. And look up at the Companion when you have a moment. Whatever it is and wherever it came from, there is something in its light that reminds a person why it is worth fighting for the things that matter.

May the Companion light your way.

Office of the High Rider, Elturel